concerning economic development and modernization. By extension, this required navigating relations with the advanced industrial economies—the United States, Soviet Union, and their European allies—which would be the most likely partners for economic assistance, trade, and technology. How India navigated Non-Alignment in practice would have important implications for India's development and economic objectives.

India initially attempted to establish closer ties with the Western bloc between 1947 and 1955. India was a founding member of the United Nations, then an international institution established by the victors of World War II. It also participated in the Bretton Woods conference in 1944 to manage the post-war economic order and joined Western-led organizations such as the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) as early as 1948. [29] Nehru and Patel were also concerned about the spread of violent communist movements in India, of a kind that the Soviet Union had been known to sponsor. Although Nehru had expressed strong support for the Soviet Union as a prospective anti-colonial ally—including at the Brussels Congress of 1927—and visited the USSR that year, his views on the Soviets moderated somewhat after the excesses of Stalinism had started to come to light in the 1930s. [30] In fact, Nehru assured US Ambassador Loy Henderson in 1950 that 'in the event of a World War . . . [India] would not side with the Communists'. [31]

Still, independent India's relations with Washington began on a cautious note: despite commonalities, there were a fair number of frictions related to Western backing for Pakistan, US priorities in Europe, different assessments of Communist China, and India's decolonization agenda. Moreover, despite India's need for economic and agricultural aid, there were clear cultural and ideological differences between Nehru's government and Harry Truman's administration in the United States. [32] Future US Secretary of State John Foster Dulles—then representing the US government in the United Nations—had already expressed scepticism of India's leadership before Indian independence when he declared that 'In India, Soviet Communism exercises a strong influence through the interim Hindu government.' [33]